

You can explore this further by creating a team of decision-makers, the second line of leadership, where you can accept decisions by a minimum quorum.

Interestingly, blockchain uses a similar logic for autonomously approving transactions. It will reduce your workload. Additionally, it will also improve your speed of operation without increasing the risk.

Distributed leadership fundamentally differs from its traditional counterpart by focusing on collaboration and resource sharing versus resource allocation or distribution.

It is interactive and peer-to-peer versus being siloed. Therefore, it can offer adequate checks and balances for decision-making.

The future

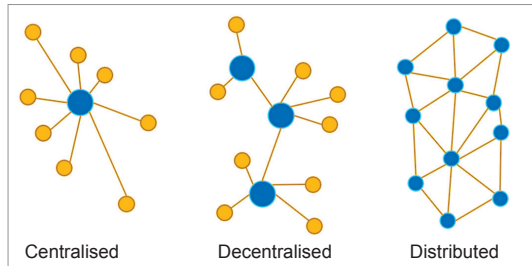
Futuristic organisations, for the next decade or more, will have a multi-generational workforce. To make this employee mix work well, you must provide the right infrastructure, establish appropriate systems, and create the right environment. This will enable people to do their best.

Although it sounds like general advice every man and his dog seem to offer these days, the key is in its provenance.

Distributed leadership relies on people who lead with a definite purpose, intent, and knowledge. These are genuine thought leaders. And those who collaborate with other thought leaders are the influential ones. Now is the time for influential thought leadership to take the lead and build futuristic businesses.

This new leadership model has immense potential to improve business agility and help build a culture of diversity.

By design, there is no single point of failure. Yet, the ability to solve complex problems can increase—there is a need for participation and excellence, consensus, accountability, and sound decisions.



Leadership structures and evolution

But there is a caveat

However, remember that a poorly designed model is prone to decision deadlocks. The selection of members is also crucial. But you can easily avoid these issues by setting up ground rules and appropriate systems.

The new form of leadership might be a touchy subject for many. Many senior leaders feel this as a threat to their empire (whatever that means). However, this is not the case with progressive leaders who comfortably embrace new challenges and are forward thinkers.

In all the projects that I have worked on until now, there is a common thread of change management and communication. And I have directly worked with nearly a dozen companies by now. And I would have catered to over 65+ businesses, mostly around innovation, business improvements, technology implementations, and so on.

But in both cases, change management or communication, if you miss the mark, success is at risk. Sometimes things fail; sometimes, they just become dysfunctional.

I have seen that happening in a multicultural environment, which is pretty much every second company in the world right now.

If you think about why it happens, you will find that lack of diversity, lack of inclusion, lack of employee involvement plays a crucial role.

While achieving diversity is easier, being inclusive and empowering employees for decision-making

is harder to pull off. Especially when pale-male-stale ideologies are still floating around, it is a tough environment for many.

The advantage is, once you come through this mental block, experimentation can increase significantly. It essentially means innovation

becomes easier for you. Implementation must follow, of course.

So, now what?

As indicated earlier, distributed leadership can quickly become a touchy subject. That, too, because high-speed innovation can be a hard sell (or buy). So here is a quick test you can do. Why not run a controlled experiment and try a few things?

Create a team of high-calibre leaders from your talent pool. Maintain cross-functionality. First, coach them, then offload some of your decision-making, and set up guidelines. Run distributed leadership experiment for a few months and review effectiveness.

Check what is working or not working and what you can do better. See what worked and what did not. Did it help you become more innovative, futuristic, and agile? If yes, then rinse and repeat.

One of the essential antidotes for leading in a volatile and uncertain world is the culture of experimentation. This culture must be established throughout the organisation to see the true benefits of experimentation efforts. The good part is, when you master the art of experimentation you will also master the art of innovation. 

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